Their loyalty, dedication and commitment and the readiness to bear privations along with the soldiers whom they served was indeed commendable, and this tradition continues till date. Of course, the fact that there have been some real sharks also amongst them cannot be denied!

The 9 Maratha LI was raised on 1 October 1964 at Belgaum. The battalion was created from scratch. The first day of our existence was historic for all of us who were present. I had to merely step across from the Regimental Centre at Belgaum to the new unit, and happened to be among the first few officers to join the battalion. First of all, there was a prayer ceremony attended by us, the pioneers. This was followed by a 'Sainik Sammelan' (a formal interaction with all ranks) by Major K.L. Awasthi, the second-in-command. The gathering on that occasion comprised a few officers, including myself, some JCOs and about 300 soldiers. It was an unforgettable experience for all of us. Major K.L. Awasthi officiated as the commanding officer (CO) till Lieutenant Colonel M.B. Wadke arrived and took charge of the battalion.

We received orders to move to Nagaland in mid-1965. The battalion moved by a special military train from Belgaum to Dimapur. Though the journey was a great experience, it took us forever to reach our destination. Being a peacetime move, our train was given the lowest priority, even lower than goods trains. The rolling stock or the bogies that formed the train were the worst available and in a poor state of maintainance too. The batteries which ran the lights and fans in the compartments required to be charged very frequently. We would spend hours sweating it out in the oppressive heat and unbearable humidity. Nights were comparatively cooler but often without any lights.

For a youngster like me, it was the strangest train journey. The train was the mobile home for 800 troops for over ten days. The officers had a first-class compartment, the junior commissioned officers were given a second-class one, and the rest of the train comprised third-class bogies. Ordinary covered wagons meant for goods were converted into kitchens. The conditions inside these metal boxes were hot as hell, perhaps a shade worse than the boiler